to the ground. This year, CPCB estimated PM10 to be 400 on certain days and PM2.5 at around 600—a value that would see European cities shut down altogether.

Yet, the government insists things are on the mend. "Delhi observed lowest average AQI in the past eight years," the Union environment ministry told the Lok Sabha this month. "The number of 'good' days (AQI under 200) in Delhi increased to 200 in 2025 from 110 in 2016. While there is overall improvement in AQI this year, 'very poor' (AQI: 301-400) and 'severe' days (400+ AQI) have reduced from 71 in 2024 to 50 in 2025." What this data fails to capture is the fact that the Capital recorded its highest streak of 'very poor' air days since 2019, with CPCB data recording 23 consecutive days of 300+ AQI beginning November 6.

Where is Delhi going wrong? And what needs to be done?

Capital Car-nage

Automobile pollution is still one of the biggest culprits in Delhi's smog-choked air—tied with industrial emissions (even though that used to include fumes from coal plants) and construction dust. The Supreme Court directive of getting polluting petrol cars 15 years of age or older and diesel ones 10 years or above off the road is honoured more in the breach. Had it been observed, 4.75 million such vehicles would have been deregistered from 2018-2021. Instead, only 2.98 million were removed. Today, 10.6 million vehicles in the NCR qualify as overaged. What is worse, the new Delhi government put brakes on the drive, calling the age cap 'arbitrary' and 'unscientific'. In August, it told the Supreme Court that fitness, not age should determine roadworthiness.

TRANSPORT

FAILURE
DELHI HAS BEEN UNABLE TO IMPLEMENT THE BAN THAT PROHIBITS PETROL VEHICLES 10 YEARS OR OLDER AND DIESEL ONES 15 YRS OR OLDER FROM PLYING ON ITS ROADS

SOLUTION
REPLACE AGE BAN WITH A SCIENCE-BASED LOW EMISSION ZONE ENFORCED BY AUTOMATED CAMERAS THAT FINE NON-COMPLIANT VEHICLES

The catch? Delhi has just one automated fitness centre—in Jhuljhuli—which can test only 48,000 vehicles a year. "If age is not the criterion, the government must clearly define how vehicles will be evaluated, what alternatives exist, and the supporting infrastructure," says Gaurav Vangaal of automotive market research and forecasting firm S&P Global Mobility.

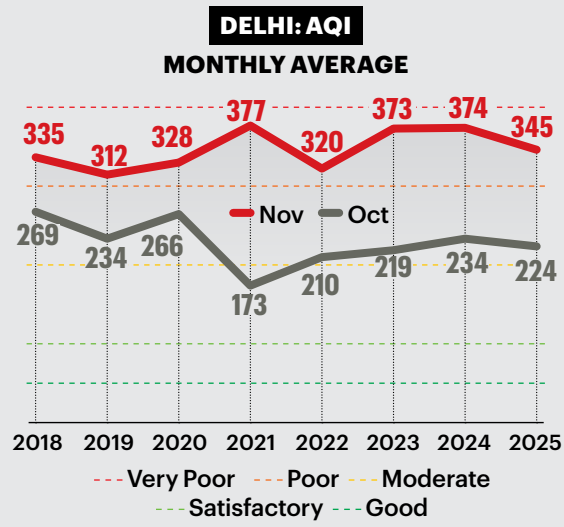
Then there is the scam called PUC, or the pollution-under-control certification. A 2023 audit by the Comptroller and Auditor General revealed how more than 108,000 vehicles were issued PUC certificates despite failing emission tests. Around 76,865 were generated in under a minute, impossible for diesel vehicles that require multiple throttle cycles. Another 7,643 showed the same equipment simultaneously 'testing' multiple vehicles.

PUC centres, run by private operators, have become rubber-stamp counters. The Delhi transport department looked away, letting a city of 10 million-plus vehicles run on a broken system of pollution gatekeepers. "PUC operators get hackers to exploit vulnerabilities in the PUC software. Once inserted, it allows the user to manually edit the emission data and issue a certificate," says Anil Chhikara, senior faculty at the Asian Institute of Transport Development, and

WHAT'S CHOK

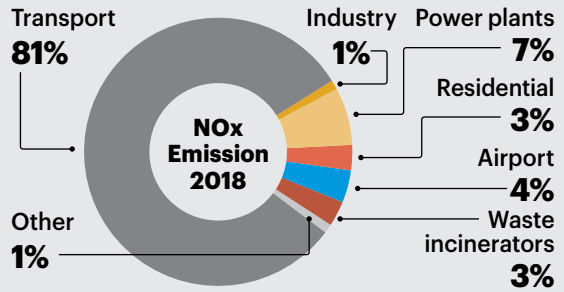
POISON IN THE AIR

November AQIs have consistently breached 300+ mark for the past 8 years



NOXIOUS NO_x

Vehicular congestion remains the highest emitter of poisonous nitrogen oxides



NOx: *Nitrogen oxides in the Air Quality Index that can irritate the airways*

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY